

4.2 Managing Files, Folders, And Documents

Windows XP creates many folders such as ‘My Pictures’, and such folders are by default used by applications to store their files—unless the user decides to save it elsewhere. Novice users may love the idea, but it is not entirely safe to use such ‘friendly’ folders; we tell you why in §4.2.3. Before that, let’s get down to understanding the basic filesystem of Windows XP.

Windows XP installs itself on a primary partition, and if it is the only OS on your hard disk, then it is most likely called the C: drive. Let’s assume C: is your primary drive, for the sake of convenience.

4.2.1 The Default File System

Here, we try and explain what type of file is stored under what folder, rather than going into the details of each file.

The ‘C:\Windows’ folder stores files that are of critical importance for proper functioning of the OS. This folder contains the all-important ‘System32’ folder that not only stores .dll (dynamic link library) files responsible for the functioning of many process and services, but also contains the kernel (krnl386) for Windows XP and its dll. Now you know why files in ‘System32’ are more prone to virus attacks!

The Windows theme also finds a place in C:\Windows\Resources\Themes. Other folders such as AppPatch, Fonts and System also contain files that are closely associated with the functioning of the operating system. Basically, you don’t want to mess with the files in the ‘C:\Windows’ folder!

The ‘Program Files’ folder located under the root of the C: drive is assigned as the parent folder for installation of different software. Every software, by default, installs into ‘C:\Program Files\Software Name’; however, this default method of installation can be altered if the software allows the user to customise the installation procedure and choose a different path.